

Irish Goodbye

This next song is about immigration.

In our house growing up, immigrants were sacred.

My grandmother came through Ellis Island from Germany. My great-great-grandfather kept a diary of his voyage in 1863 — and almost every day he recorded how many people died crossing the ocean.

Most of my ancestors were German Catholic immigrants who settled in small Kansas towns where there were already small Catholic communities waiting for them.

In our house, immigrants weren't the enemy. They were family. They were sacrifice. They were survival. They were the reason we were here.

And I've always believed immigration — messy and complicated as it is — is part of the secret sauce of this country. The energy. The work ethic. The hunger to build something new.

So when immigration becomes anger and accusation — just another political talking point — it hurts.

Especially knowing that nearly every one of us is here because someone else crossed a line first.

When I started digging into my wife's family history, I found something interesting. Her grandfather first came to this country from County Kerry, Ireland... not exactly by the book. He eventually returned and came back legally — but like a lot of immigrants, his first step onto American soil wasn't simple.

History has a short memory.

This song is loosely based on that story.

And the title comes from a phrase you may have heard — an "Irish goodbye." If you don't know what that means... it's when someone slips out quietly without saying a word.

Sometimes leaving quietly isn't rude.

Sometimes it's survival.

This is for Patrick Sheehan.

And its called "Irish Goodbye."

